

TRoyMEDIA — Oblomov Script Development Brief

Report date: 2026-09-23 | Prepared for: TRoy (CEO) | Status: real, grounded first output — not yet a client deliverable

Summary

The founder pushed back on an earlier status claim: the Publishing department had been described as having "completed its first real task" when it had actually only passed a connectivity test — no real client manuscript had gone through it. His correction: **"alive" is not the same as "working."** Something technically connected but producing no real output "lives like dead."

That correction applies directly to the Oblomov film project too. Oblomov has been publicly disclosed as an in-development TRoyMEDIA project since 2026-09-20, but a code check found the Production & Casting department had **never actually been given the real source novel** — the Script Development Specialist agent had no search or page-reading tools at all, and the Casting Director had search but no page-reading tool. Any script or casting work started today would have had to work from the model's own training memory of a 167-year-old novel, not the real text. That is exactly the gap the founder flagged: the site said the project existed; nothing in the backend actually knew where to start.

Fix applied (code, not just copy):

- ``agency/departments/production.py`` — gave the Script Development Specialist real ``search`` + ``scrape`` tools (Serper web search + page reading, the same real tools already used elsewhere in this codebase), and gave the Casting Director the ``scrape`` tool as well as its existing ``search``.
- Updated both agents' instructions to require looking up the real source work before writing any notes, and to never invent plot/character details for a source they haven't actually read.
- Restarted the live backend service (``backend.troymediagency.com``, port 8200) so the change took effect; the self-healing watchdog brought it back online in ~3 seconds.

Then verified live, not just claimed: ran a real ``SCRIPT_DEVELOPMENT`` task through the actual production system, asking it to ground its notes in the real novel. Full real output below.

What the agent actually did

The agent's own output opens with: *"Now I have comprehensive knowledge of the actual novel Oblomov by Ivan Goncharov. I can now write script development notes based on the real source material,"* and closes citing its real source: **Project Gutenberg's edition, translated by C. J. Hogarth, 1915** — the real, public-domain English translation it searched for and read, not a memory of the book's reputation.

Script Development Notes (real output, verbatim)

Story/Concept Direction

The novel *Oblomov* (1859) is a penetrating character study of paralysis — both personal and societal. It follows Ilya Ilyich Oblomov, a minor Russian nobleman living in St. Petersburg, whose defining trait is his complete inability to engage with life. The core conflict is not a traditional plot-driven narrative but rather a psychological and philosophical meditation on inertia: Oblomov literally cannot leave his apartment or bed despite genuine reasons he should (an urgent letter from his estate manager, his declining financial situation, his own growing awareness of his wasted potential).

The emotional core lies in the tension between what Oblomov could be (intelligent, sensitive, capable of genuine love) and what he chooses to become (a man who sleeps through life, delegating every responsibility, living in a dressing-gown). This is not stupidity or mental illness — Goncharov makes clear that Oblomov possesses intellect and moral sensitivity. His paralysis is psychological and spiritual, rooted in his childhood conditioning at Oblomovka, a place designed to ask nothing of him.

The novel's power derives from Goncharov's refusal to offer either satire or pity. He renders Oblomov with genuine affection even as he charts his complete dissolution. When Oblomov's friend Schtoltz tells him "Now or never," the phrase becomes the novel's moral fulcrum: Oblomov chooses "never," and the choice destroys his life.

Structure Notes

The novel is organized in four parts, each serving a distinct structural purpose:

Part I (approximately 50 pages) establishes Oblomov's world through a single morning. He receives a letter from his estate manager requiring immediate action. He cannot bring himself to leave his bed. Various visitors arrive (his friend Schtoltz, a bureaucrat, a writer, Taranteyev — a scheming "friend"). Each interaction exposes Oblomov's paralysis and his elaborate rationalizations for it. The section is comic in tone but troubling in implication.

Part I, Chapter 5 (the dream section) shifts into Oblomovka — Oblomov's childhood estate. This extended flashback reveals the source of his paralysis: a childhood of absolute safety, constant care, and zero demands. The dream establishes that Oblomovka is not merely a place but a psychological state: "the disease of Oblomovka" (Oblomovshchina). This dream section explains the protagonist's entire adult failure and is essential to any adaptation.

Part II introduces Olga, a young woman of unusual intelligence and moral seriousness. She and Oblomov fall in love; her presence seems to awaken him. But when marriage and commitment require action, Oblomov retreats, writing her a letter breaking off their engagement. Olga recognizes his cowardice and breaks with him; she eventually marries Schtoltz, his friend.

Part III shows Oblomov adrift and ill, exploited by Taranteyev and his brother. Schtoltz must rescue him repeatedly. Oblomov takes lodgings with a widow, Agafia Matvievna, who becomes devoted to him. He marries her and settles into a second Oblomovka — cared for absolutely, asked to do nothing.

Part IV shows Oblomov's slow physical and moral decline. He suffers a stroke, deteriorates, and dies in his sleep, having never left his "nest." Schtoltz adopts Oblomov's son and raises him. Years later Schtoltz encounters Zakhar, Oblomov's old servant, now a beggar, who speaks of his master with profound love and sorrow.

Thematic Architecture for Adaptation

A strong feature-film adaptation would need to carry three levels of meaning:

- **The Personal/Romantic Level** — Oblomov's love for Olga and his inability to choose her. Emotionally intelligible to a modern audience: his failure isn't that he doesn't love her, but that he cannot act on it.
- **The Psychological/Developmental Level** — Oblomov as victim of his own childhood, so completely cared-for that he has no muscles (psychological or physical) for autonomous life.
- **The Social/Political Level** — Oblomov as symptom of a dying Russian aristocracy, published in 1859, shortly before the emancipation of the serfs (1861). Schtoltz — part-German, practical, forward-looking — represents the new Russia.

Open Questions for the Brief Owner

- What is the primary emotional core to emphasize — the romantic tragedy, the psychological tragedy, or the social allegory? A feature film typically needs one primary anchor.
- How should the Oblomovka flashback/dream be handled — a single extended sequence, or interwoven throughout? Naturalistic or stylized?
- Tone and genre — tragedy, psychological study, dark comedy, or a hybrid? The novel mixes comic elements (Taranteyev is farcical) with profound pathos.
- Ending — stop at Oblomov's death and Zakhar's testimony, or linger on Schtoltz's adoption of the boy (suggesting redemption/legacy)?
- Historical setting — Goncharov's 1859 Russia, or a different period/contemporary setting?
- Supporting characters — how much screen time for Schtoltz? For the Taranteyev fraud subplot? Is Olga co-protagonist or primarily Oblomov's mirror?
- Visual strategy — Oblomov spends most of the novel in one room, often in bed. How do you open this spatially for cinema without losing the thematic claustrophobia?

Final Note on Source Fidelity (agent's own words)

"The brief requested that I ground this in the actual novel, not in cultural memory of it. Having read the full text (Project Gutenberg edition, translated by C. J. Hogarth, 1915), I can confirm that this work is far more psychologically nuanced and compassionate than its reputation might suggest. Oblomov is not a villain or even a fool. He is a good man, intelligent and sensitive, who is broken by circumstances and by his own nature. The novel's moral sophistication lies in Goncharov's refusal to blame or mock him — even as the novel documents his complete failure to live. That tension is the heart of the material and should be preserved in any adaptation."

Status, honestly

This is a real, grounded first output — the department now genuinely knows where to start, and the open questions above are real decisions TRoy needs to make, not filler. It is **not** a client deliverable, a greenlit production, or a claim that casting/production has begun. No director, cast, or release date is confirmed. The next real step is TRoy answering the open questions above so a real treatment can follow.